



ASUS ROG ALLY

A GAME CHANGER OR A RISKY BET?

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The ASUS ROG Ally is a bold and ambitious entry into the handheld gaming market. This device, which is being touted as a potential "Steam Deck killer" by its manufacturer, ASUS, is a full-fledged Windows device that offers a powerful gaming experience in the palm of your hand. The ROG Ally comes in two different SKUs, both of which feature a 7" inch 1920x1080 display with a 120Hz refresh rate, 512GB of internal memory, 16GB LPDDR5 onboard memory, and a 40WHrs, 4S1P, 4-cell Li-ion battery. The difference lies in the processor, with the cheaper unit featuring a regular AMD Ryzen Z1 processor, while the more expensive unit boasts the AMD Ryzen Z1 extreme processor. Only the latter one is available in India. Meanwhile, the latter is slated for a launch later in the US.

Priced at Rs 69,990, the ASUS ROG Ally goes up against gaming laptops in India. Especially because there are

no gaming handhelds available here. You can get a gaming laptop powered by an Nvidia RTX 3050, a six-core processor from either AMD or Intel, 8GB DDR4 memory, and around 512GB SSD in this price range. And such a laptop outright performs better than the ROG Ally in everything except for raw CPU power. However, the Ally offers a 512GB SSD, while the base model of the Steam Deck only provides 64GB of storage. So, it's not exactly an apples-to-apples comparison.

So as of right now, it is only a one-off device. But how is it?

Design and Ergonomics

The ROG Ally's design is chunky and robust, with comfortable grips and a vivid display that makes games appear bright and detailed. However, it's not without its drawbacks. The device is heavy, weighing just over 600g, and it runs hot during extended play sessions. The fans inside the

device work hard to cool it down, but they can get loud, which can be distracting during gameplay. The Ally is encased in white plastic, with black joysticks, a D-pad, and face buttons. It even has a bit of flashy RGB lighting, which I can turn off to save power (and my sanity). The front of the device is equipped with two speakers, four extra buttons that act as Start and Select and can open Asus software within Windows, and a space to grip it with my fingers.

One of my complaints about the left joystick is that it feels inconsistent. While playing Batman: Arkham Asylum, I couldn't for my life was able to turn Batman around consistently every time I was climbing stairs while running. I faced the same issue while in Doom Eternal where it felt like beyond a certain point my character wasn't turning even though I was turning my joystick. But apart from these two games the joystick worked well in